Introduction

THE HUMAN-AI WORKPLACE HAS ARRIVED

by Elisa Farri and Gabriele Rosani

In 2025 the integration of technology into business is moving to the next level. A new collaborative dynamic that HBR readers have been anticipating for some time has finally arrived: The world of work is no longer technology on one side and humans on the other. Now, natural language interfaces are facilitating humanlike dialogue with machines. Organizations increasingly understand that AI is a collaborator, not just a tool. Workplaces are becoming a "fusion" of humans and machines working in tandem, cocreating as never before.

As this collection of HBR articles on tech will show, we should expect the trend of human-machine fusion to accelerate. This will be made possible by the greater role of AI, in synergy with other technologies ranging from robotics and biometrics to spatial computing. In "Robots Are Changing the Face of Customer Service," Alicia A. Grandey and Kayley Morris explain how to integrate robot technology in ways that will deliver value to customers—in the form of a superior customer experience—in places like hotels, restaurants, and shops. In these cases, success is determined by three factors: functionality (What can robots do?); interaction (Are robots perceived as emotional beings?); and acceptance (Are customers and coworkers willing to collaborate with robots?). Another technology that facilitates the fusion of humans and machines is spatial computing, which uses AI, computer vision, augmented and virtual reality, and other technologies to integrate virtual experiences into a person's experience of the physical world. As Cathy Hackl writes in "How Early-Adopter Companies Are Thinking About Apple Vision Pro," spatial computing allows people to interact with each other and with technology in new ways. For example, this growing integration enables human-machine communication in which eye movements and gestures replace clicks and taps.

Today's generative AI systems—such as OpenAI's ChatGPT—can collaborate with humans to tackle diverse problems and achieve multiple goals. Consider, for instance, the scenario depicted by Amy Webb in "How to Prepare for a Gen AI Future You Can't Predict": an insurance firm where underwriters collaborate with AI. Initially the underwriter asks AI to generate a risk evaluation for insuring a property. Then the underwriter analyzes the AI-generated output and might ask AI to refine the assessment in an iterative way using different data sources, such as images from inspection reports. By working together, the underwriter and AI create an optimal quote.

In this new reality of technology integration, leaders will need to rethink and manage the allocation of tasks between humans and intelligent machines. They must find the optimal balance, avoid the pitfalls of over- and underdelegation, and ensure that potential risks are appropriately considered and managed. Organizations that succeed in these challenges will increase their competitive advantage.

To achieve this fusion, new skills will be needed and workflows will require adjustments. Companies must abandon outdated models of operation and management. Individual and collective responsibility for use will also be essential. Let's briefly examine each of these aspects and pinpoint where you can find more details within the book.

Tasks. Individual jobs are composed of many different tasks that will increasingly be performed collaboratively by humans and machines. In "Generative AI and the Transformation of Knowledge Work," Maryam Alavi and George Westerman emphasize how the capabilities of generative AI can enhance the human ability to perform cognitively challenging tasks and facilitate faster and more effective learning of new tasks. The key question leaders must ask is no longer what machines can do versus what humans can do, but rather what tasks they can accomplish together through new collaborative dynamics.

Skills. There will be a demand for new skills, an obvious one being the ability to manage new AI tools. In large organizations, academies will play a central role in training employees on human-machine collaboration. In "Using 'Digital Academies' to Close the Skills Gap," Rubén Mancha and Salvatore Parise describe the success factors for upskilling programs. Learning comes from a blend of experiential, peer, and formal instruction, as well as when employees bring in on-the-job projects. AI can also act as a trainer or coach, with the potential to provide an always-on, personalized learning experience. Encouraging bottom-up approaches, such as communities of practice, promotes faster adoption through experimentation and shared learning.

Workflows. The fusion of humans and machines will change both internal workflows and customer-facing touchpoints. Looking ahead to the future, it will be necessary to redesign operating models and restructure organizations in ways we can't predict today. In her article, Amy Webb offers a framework leaders can use to prepare. One important aspect is a mindset shift: stop thinking solely in terms of process efficiency and instead focus on the new opportunities for revenue growth. As Alex Tapscott describes in "Web3 Could Change the Business Model of Creative Work," creators can thrive alongside AI rather than suffer at its expense. For example, they might be able to use smart contracts to ensure they are compensated when their work is used to train an AI algorithm.

Judgment. For businesses, new technologies come with various interrelated effects. Some of these are unintended consequences, including data-related risks and potential biases, as well as environmental implications. The articles in Section 2, "Tech Questions and Controversies," cover some of these dilemmas and trade-offs. Fortunately, humans have the ability to judge. When workers use generative AI, for example, they should be mindful of potential hallucinations or biases, anticipate errors, and exercise their judgment both individually and as a team. Leaders should encourage critical thinking by setting clear guidelines for the responsible use of AI technology. Rashik Parmar, Marc Peters, and Llewellyn D.W. Thomas present one such framework in their article "What Is Responsible Computing?"

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This book lays out a clear path toward what we call a "HumanAIzed" business reality, where the fusion of humans and intelligent machines occurs seamlessly and at scale. As this human-machine convergence accelerates, new opportunities will emerge along with increased risks.

Many of the authors in this collection agree that it's difficult to predict the pace of organizational change. But one thing is certain: This year you'll see an increasing and continuing fusion of AI technology and human work in your organization. In 2025, companies must evolve and change to become more "HumanAIzed" in their own way, embracing and adapting to the fusion of humans and machines. Good leaders will inspire their people to understand and embrace this new form of collaboration. They must not remain stuck in the old ways of operating. There is no way back.